

THE LITERAL GENIE LESSON • AI LITERACY

How to Talk to AI

A 45-minute prompt-writing lesson. The hook: AI is a literal genie — it grants exactly what your words ask for, not what your brain meant. Students learn to write genie-proof prompts.

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	Cursed Wish Repair Shop worksheet (1 per student)	Optional — works fully unplugged	Print worksheets. That's it.

OBJECTIVES

- Students can explain why the same AI gives different quality answers to different prompts.
- Students can apply the **P.R.O. framework** (Purpose, Requirements, Output) to write a clear prompt.
- Students can evaluate an AI response for accuracy and identify when to double-check it.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

ISTE 1.5.c

ISTE 1.6.a

ISTE 1.1.c

CCSS ELA W.6.4

Full standards text in the Teacher Guide.

WARM-UP — THE WORST GENIE EVER (7 MIN)

Announce that you are a genie, and you grant wishes *exactly as worded*. Take 3–4 wishes from the class and ruin every one, cheerfully:

"I wish I was rich." → "Done. Your name is now Rich."

"I wish for a million dollars." → "Granted — one million dollars, in Monopoly money."

"I wish school was over." → "Granted. The school building is now over... there."

Then ask: **whose fault was that — the genie's, or the wish?**

Bridge: "AI works like that genie. It doesn't know what you meant — it only knows what you SAID. It grants your words, not your thoughts. Today you learn to write wishes with fine print."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION — THE THREE CLAUSES OF A GENIE-PROOF WISH (8 MIN)

Lawyers make contracts genie-proof with clauses. Strong prompts have three — write **P.R.O.** on the board:

P — Purpose. What do you actually want, and who is it for? *"Explain photosynthesis to a 6th grader"* beats *"explain photosynthesis."*

R — Requirements. The fine print: length, tone, format, what to include, what to avoid. This is what stops the genie from twisting your wish.

O — Output. What should the granted wish look like? A list? A paragraph? A table? A plan?

Model it live (on the board or with a projected AI tool):

CURSED WISH	GENIE-PROOF P.R.O. PROMPT
"help with my history essay"	"I'm writing a 5-paragraph essay for 7th grade history on why the printing press mattered. Give me 3 possible thesis statements and 2 pieces of evidence for each, as a bullet list. Don't write the essay for me."

Say it plainly: "Notice the last clause — *don't write the essay for me*. If the genie writes your essay, it's not your wish that came true — and everyone finds out eventually. Use AI to think **WITH** you, not **FOR** you."

ACTIVITY — CURSED WISH REPAIR SHOP (20 MIN)

- Repair (8 min):** Solo, students rewrite the three cursed wishes on the worksheet using all three P.R.O. clauses.
- Break it (7 min):** Pairs swap sheets. Partners play the Worst Genie Ever: they try to misread each repaired wish as literally as possible, then score it with the Genie-Proof Checklist. If the genie can still twist it, it needs more fine print.
- Showcase (5 min):** 2–3 students read a "cursed → genie-proof" before-and-after. If devices are available, run the best one live and critique what comes back.

EXIT TICKET (5 MIN)

Bottom of worksheet: students write one genie-proof prompt they could actually use this week for another class, and name **one thing they'd double-check** in the AI's answer before trusting it.

DIFFERENTIATION

- Support:** Provide the P.R.O. sentence starters (Teacher Guide, p.2).
- Extension:** Students write a wish that **CAN'T** be genie-proofed in under 50 words, then explain why specificity has limits.

- **No-device classrooms:** Built in — the teacher and partners ARE the genie. No AI tool required at any step.